

FINALLY: THE AFFORDABLE DIY MIKVAH

SHLIACH DISCOVERS
CREATIVE MEN'S
MIKVAH SOLUTION

CONTRIBUTORS

RABBI MENDEL LIBEROW
MORGAN HILL, CALIFORNIA

RABBI GERSHON GROSSBAUM
S. PAUL, MINNESOTA

WRITTEN BY ASHIRA WEISS

REVIEWED BY

DAYAN LEVI YITZCHOK RASKIN
LONDON, ENGLAND

RABBI YOSEF SHUSTERMAN
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA





IT WAS KISLEV 5778, and Rabbi and Mrs. Mendel Liberow had just moved on shlichus to Morgan Hill, a city on the southern tip of Silicon Valley in Northern California. As the couple got used to the lay of the land and adjusted to life on shlichus, Rabbi Liberow made a resolution: “There are so many things we can’t currently do here, such as daven with a minyan daily or hear krias haTorah on Shabbos. I want to do something that can help me consistently uphold chassidishe standards despite whatever may or may not be available.” And so, the idea of building a men’s mikvah was born.

In *Likkutei Torah*, the Alter Rebbe specifies three prerequisites for a proper davening: going to the mikvah, giving tzedakah, and learning Chassidus. The Alter Rebbe states that using the mikvah before davening brings a person an added measure of kedushah, unrelated to the purification attained when tevilas Ezra is relevant.

The word *tevilah* can be seen as an anagram of the word *bitul*, with the act of tevilah representing a complete bitul in the waters of kedushah. This adds emphasis as to why tevilah in a mikvah is a key element in the hanhagah of a chossid.

Rabbi Liberow knew there was a way to construct a mikvah without considerable construction costs, as his father-in-law, Rabbi Faivish Dalfin, had converted a jacuzzi into a mikvah in a small garden shed outside his Bais Chabad in



North Bay Village, Florida. So, Rabbi Liberow started to investigate.

The price of a jacuzzi started at about \$3,000, and there would be additional costs to install it, build some kind of enclosure, and maintain it. “There must be a cheaper way,” thought Rabbi Liberow.

In order for a men’s mikvah to be kosher, it cannot be a keili, and it must be attached to the ground. Rabbi Liberow called Rabbi Gershon Grossbaum, shliach in S. Paul, Minnesota and noted expert in mikvah construction, who said he gets a handful of such inquiries each year. He suggested that Rabbi Liberow fashion a mikvah out of a portable pool.

Rabbi Grossbaum cautioned that the proposed mikvah is not a suitable alternative for someone who has access to an established mikvah. Is it better than toiveling in a swimming pool, though? “If the filter is off, an in-ground pool may be slightly better. However, if

the filter is on, a swimming pool doesn’t satisfy [the criteria of] mikveh mayim,” Rabbi Grossbaum had said.

With detailed instructions in hand on how to make a hole at the bottom of such a pool and how to attach it to the ground in a halachically kosher way, Rabbi Liberow went on a hunt for an appropriate and affordable product.

He found above-ground pools that could have worked, but since they weren’t heated they would pose a problem in colder weather. A special portable pool designed for goyishe conversions, l’havdil, could have worked too, but such pools were priced at \$1,500 and up. Then Rabbi Liberow discovered the inflatable hot tub. The small tub came with inflatable vinyl walls and an attached heater. And the best part was that Amazon sold them for about \$350.

“I bought the cheapest one because I’m renting and don’t know how for long I’ll be living here, but it’s amazing how for a few hundred dollars I can uphold a practice so crucial to darkei hachassidus,” says Rabbi Liberow. The jacuzzi option would

probably last longer, he posits, but the affordability and portability of the inflatable hot tub make it more appealing to someone on a tight budget or with rented accommodations.

Maintenance is easy and cheap too, as the hot tub heats the water inside the pool, so long-term expenses include just the cost of the electricity and water. Hygiene is not a problem; the hot tub comes with an integrated water filtration system as well as a chlorine dispenser, and the water can be changed as often as necessary. As far as safety is concerned, the model Rabbi Liberow purchased includes a cover with a child-proof buckle closure.

Rabbi Liberow set the hot tub in his garage and installed a lock on the inside of the garage door for privacy. It took about a half-hour to assemble the hot tub, and another half-hour to drill a hole and attach the hot tub to the ground as per Rabbi Grossbaum’s instructions.

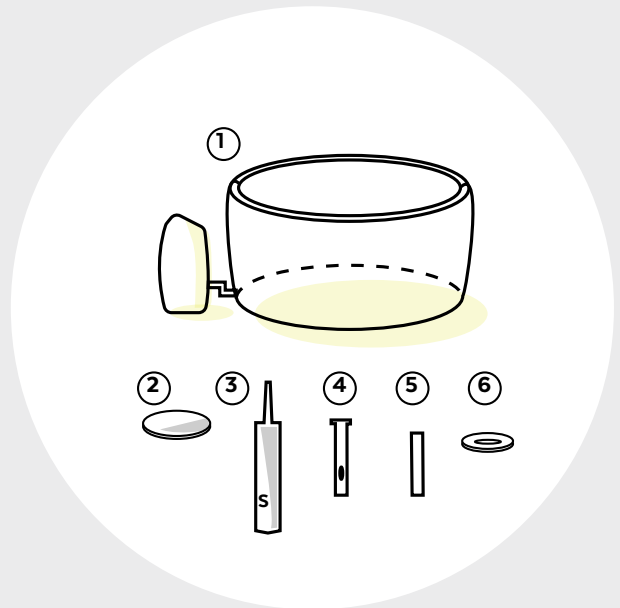
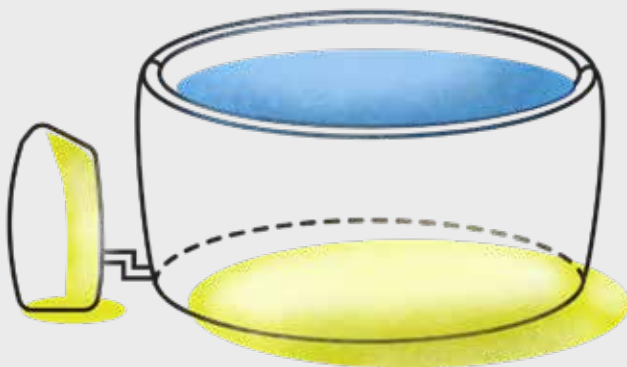
Ever since having installed the mikvah, Rabbi Liberow has shared the idea with many other shluchim, and it has been implemented in a number of locations around the world. With the various restrictions that have arisen due to COVID-19, a few shluchim in Eretz Yisroel and the United Kingdom who had previously enjoyed access to a mikvah but were prevented from doing so for the foreseeable future were also inspired to each install a hot tub mikvah on their property.

Recently, Rabbi Liberow’s brother shared with him that while in Ukraine, he had visited a shliach who sometimes breaks the ice at the local river to toivel on erev yom tov and had expressed how he wished he had the ability to go to the mikvah on a more regular basis. Hearing this, Rabbi Liberow felt compelled to share his idea on a larger scale by contacting *Compass Magazine*. “Unlike a women’s mikvah, a men’s mikvah is kosher for most purposes even without rainwater. If this shliach in Ukraine were to know he could have a hot mikvah for a few hundred dollars, I’m sure he’d be overjoyed,” says Rabbi Liberow.

“I feel that mikvah keeps me on the right track,” he shares. “I’m glad I don’t have to compromise, especially on something that’s such an integral part of being a chossid. It brings kedushah and taharah and another level of hiskashrus to the Rebbe.”

Rabbi Liberow can be contacted at rabbimendelliberow@gmail.com.

HOW TO INSTALL A MIKVAH FOR TEVILAS GEVARIM ON A CONCRETE FLOOR



BY RABBI GERSHON GROSSBAUM



THE METHOD OF INSTALLATION

and the supplies needed will vary based on the type of floor to which you are connecting the mikvah. The mikvah can be placed on any flat, smooth surface in an area where it will be easy to maintain privacy. These instructions are for concrete floors, which is the most commonly used surface. Some shluchim have placed the mikvah on grass, in which case the concrete anchor is replaced with an anchor appropriate for earth.

► *Note: In order to connect the mikvah to the ground in a kosher way you will need to drill a 1/2-inch wide, 2-inch deep (13 mm x 5 cm) hole into the ground.*

► *Please note that this mikvah is only suitable for tevilas gevarim. It is not kosher for tevilas nashim or keilim.*

Rabbi Grossbaum can be contacted at
sgg@mikvahdesign.com and +1-612-386-3112.

SUPPLIES:

- Inflatable hot tub large enough for four adults, such as the Saluspa Miami, or Coleman Saluspa.¹ (The halachic requirement is for the mikvah to be capable of containing 190 gallons (approx. 720 liters) of water and also have enough space to accommodate a depth of 2 feet (60 cm) of water without overflowing while a person is toiveling. Most 4-person hot tubs fit these parameters.)
- One plexiglass circle 5 inches (12.5 cm) in diameter, ideally half an inch (1.25 cm) thick
- Bathtub waterproof silicone (the strongest you can find)
- One 1/4-inch x 2-inch (M6 x 5 cm) lag bolt
- One concrete anchor for the 1/4-inch x 2-inch (M6 x 5 cm) lag bolt
- One 1/4-inch (M6) washer

¹Due to COVID-19 there has been an increased demand for hot tubs and the prices have gone up, fluctuating according to supply and demand. At the height of the pandemic the cost was approximately \$700. As of this writing, the price has fallen to approximately \$450. A Google search for a "4-person inflatable hot tub" will give you current price comparisons.

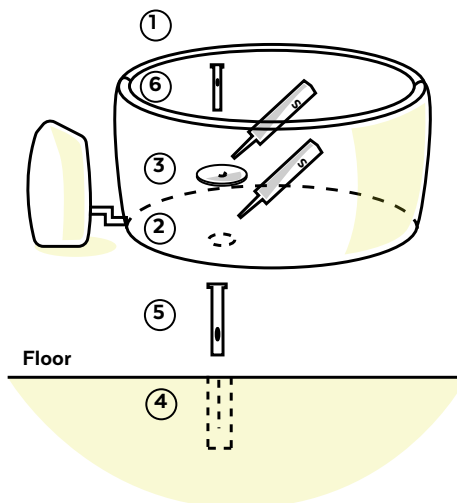
INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Inflate your hot tub.
2. Cut out a 4-inch (10 cm) diameter hole in the vinyl floor of the hot tub.
3. Using a 9/32 or 5/16 bit (7-8 mm diameter), drill a hole in the center of the plexiglass.
4. Read the instructions on the packaging of the concrete anchor. These will tell you how to correctly drill, clean, drive, and tighten the anchor to your surface. Drill a hole in the concrete, deep enough to receive the length of your anchor. Position this hole so that it will be in the center of the 4-inch (10 cm) hole in the floor of the hot tub.
5. Insert the anchor into the hole in the concrete.
6. Lay down the hot tub, aligned so that the hole in its floor will be centered around the anchor in the hole you have drilled in the concrete.
7. Squeeze a line of silicone around the perimeter of the 4-inch (10 cm) hole in the floor of the hot tub.

8. Place the plexiglass so that it overlays the silicone ring.
9. With the hole in the plexiglass directly above the anchor, squeeze a ring of silicone around the edge of the hole.
10. Press the washer onto the silicone. Then put some silicone around the hole of the washer.
11. Screw the lag bolt into the anchor and tighten everything until it is snug.
12. Silicones vary in how long they need for the seal to cure. Follow the instructions for your silicone, allowing the required time to elapse before filling your mikvah.
13. Assemble the hot tub as per the package instructions.
14. Fill the mikvah with tap water, allowing a depth of 2 feet (60 cm) for water to rise during tevilah.

The mikvah can be made slightly more mehudar by having water flow over a 16-inch (41 cm) surface as it enters the mikvah. According to some opinions this elevates water that has been gathered in pipes to have the status of flowing water. Achieving this requires constructing or using a pre-existing concrete column next to the mikvah as follows:

- Build a column of concrete blocks cemented in place next to the hot tub. The column should be tall enough to have a trough placed on top of it, from which water will flow out into the mikvah.
- Create a trough that is at least 16 inches (41 cm) long to the top of the column.
- When filling or circulating the water in your mikvah, allow the water to first run along this trough and then flow directly into the beis tevilah.





MIKVAH REFERENCE PHOTOS



Read the instructions on the packaging of the concrete anchor. These will tell you how to correctly drill, clean, drive, and tighten the anchor to your surface.



Squeeze a line of silicone around the perimeter of the 4-inch (10 cm) hole in the floor of the hot tub.



Fill the mikvah with tap water, allowing a depth of 2 feet (60 cm) for water to rise during tevilah.

